terms of the time taken and satisfaction of the recipient country. This weakness has been afflicting the whole gamut of foreign policy, but in the case of neighbours, it causes greater damage. Prime Minister Modi has tried to address it from the very beginning of the “neighbourhood first” initiative and has improved the situation in some areas significantly. But the problem will take time to get completely resolved, as there are serious structural constraints besides the questions of political will and diplomatic efficiency. There are difficulties of democratic functioning; bureaucratic procedures; coordination among diverse ministries, departments, and agencies involved in any given decision; and a variety of stakeholders with areas of mutual incompatibilities that need to be harnessed while arriving at policy decisions and implementing them.

Then there are a host of domestic political considerations that impinge on policy to mar its smooth execution. One of the most important ones in this respect is India’s federal political system. The bordering states of the Indian Union assert their stakes, notwithstanding the fact that making and implementing foreign policy is a close preserve of the central government. This is evident in many cases. For instance, in the case of Nepal, restrictions on the movement of goods was imposed keeping in mind, among other factors, the context, then in progress, of elections in the bordering state of Bihar. Modi’s ruling party, the BJP, had high stakes in that election. It was alleged in the media that by messaging toughness towards Nepal on the issue of accommodating Madhes demands in the new Constitution, the sympathies and support of the Bihari voters were sought to be mobilised, as Madhes and Bihar have close common ethnic, family, and cultural identities.[16] India’s stand on the question of the activities of Tamil fishermen in Sri Lanka, as well as on the issue of humanitarian violations in militarily ending the ethnic crisis, continues to be influenced by